



ACCELERATOR PROJECT (BST906)

MODULE DESCRIPTION

Course Leader: Joe O'Mahoney

Omahoneyj@cardiff.ac.uk

**Cardiff
Business
School**
Cardiff University

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Welcome

Welcome to the Accelerator Project! This module aims to integrate and apply what you have learned during your MBA by working as a consultant with a live client.

Specifically, you will learn to:

- ▶ Apply a consulting approach to a live problem
- ▶ Develop an effective relationship with a client
- ▶ Research & analyse organisational challenges and opportunities
- ▶ Research, propose and present viable solutions
- ▶ Manage your performance
- ▶ Craft & communicate deliverables

You will be paired with an organisation in a sector in which you have expressed an interest and will work with this organisation on a specific project that you must co-define. The project hand in is **22/07/26**. You will be assigned a Cardiff University supervisor to support your project.

Requirements

The project will ideally be a consultancy-style project which requires some research. This might be, for example, market research, new service development, writing a business plan or process redesign. The research might be qualitative or quantitative, for example, interviews with employees, researching existing literature, market analysis, surveys, or desk work.

After receiving the project brief, the students should:

1. Research the problem and the client
2. Contact their supervisor for pre-client meeting discussion & agree the ethics application
3. Submit relevant ethics forms and complete ethics training within 1 week
4. Arrange meeting with client & supervisor to meet ASAP – send interview questions & NDA in advance
5. Write agreed Statement of Work & send to supervisor & client for agreement
6. Follow up on ethics application if there are any issues
7. Start project!

It is common that the project changes slightly between the client submitting it to the course Director and the project starting. Sometimes, for example, the client expects too much and the student/supervisor should discuss a re-scoping of the project to make it more manageable. After your interview with the client you should write a 'Statement of Work' which should include:

1. Problem/Opportunity statement
2. Project context & objectives
3. Deliverables
4. Project scope
5. Stakeholders & responsibilities
6. Plan including review points
 - a. I encourage students to have a weekly review with their client
 - b. It is crucial to have a joint client/supervisor review half-way through the project
7. Risks and risk mitigation (e.g. are holidays planned?)
8. Success criteria

You **must** sign a Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA) - see below and give a copy of this to the client.

It should be made clear that you are not simply a client employee. Neither is this an internship. It is your responsibility to define, with the client, a specific research-based project for you to work on, with milestones and responsibilities. If the client is not providing this, you must contact us immediately so we can fix the issue.

If you source your own project, this must be authorised by Prof. Joe O'Mahoney prior to 5th June.





Assessment

At the end of the project you should submit (to Cardiff University) a 5,000 word management report (excluding references and appendices) on **22/7/23**. This report will be tailored to each client, marked by your supervisor and second marked by a different staff member. The Statement of Work should be included as the first Appendix. You are also expected to do a virtual presentation to the client where the client will give feedback to the supervisor. **You must include your Ethical Approval documents in the Report as well (front page or appendix).** A typical structure that you might follow for the report is:

1. Executive Summary
2. Introduction: Context; Problem statement
3. Approach: Research questions; Methods, Scope; Problem tree;
4. Findings/Analysis
5. Recommendations (prioritise, weight, plan)
6. Summary
7. Appendices (including Statement of Work and ethics documentation)

However, **the structure will very much depend on what you have been doing for the client.** You should communicate this clearly with your supervisor so that there are no surprises when the report is submitted. You may also include appendices **which are not included in the word count**. Whilst it is not necessary to include a literature review, you may find that some articles, cases or papers might provide additional material for your findings. You should use Harvard referencing for these.

Supervisor Support

- ▶ You should contact your allocated supervisor and schedule a meeting as soon as get your client details and project brief.
- ▶ Prior to the first meeting you should do your research integrity training and draft ethics form.
- ▶ Supervisors should be included in a meeting with the client as early as possible to ensure that the project is SMART (Specific, Manageable, Achievable, Realistic, Timely).
- ▶ Your supervisor will guide you through the ethics process and sign off on your ethics form if required. You must arrange a mid-project review with your supervisor & client.
- ▶ Your supervisor will not do the work for you, their role is to manage the process and provide guidance and support. They will be your first point of contact.
- ▶ You will have six hours of meetings, coaching/mentoring and guidance support with your supervisor. Your supervisor will also have additional time to review your work and give feedback, attend meetings with you client, reply to emails etc.
- ▶ Your supervisor will have time to give you dedicated one-to-one support. This can be to help with your individual report or address any issues you may be experiencing. Speak to your supervisor, they will help.
- ▶ Your supervisor will be your first marker for your work.
- ▶ Please use the marking criteria here. There is no specific weighting for different parts.
- ▶ Generally speaking, you should have at least three meetings with all three parties there: student, supervisor, client. At the beginning (SOW), in the middle (review), and at the end.

Report Marking Criteria

Your supervisor will not only assess your report, but also evaluate the client feedback that you have received, your ongoing communication with the supervisor and the way in which you have addressed any challenges encountered during the project. The supervisor will consider the following when marking your report.

Criteria	Good Practice
Client Relationship	See Feedback Form for clients below. You communicated frequently and effectively with the client. You were polite and sensible in your communication. You tried to engage with the wider client team when applicable. You had at least one review point with the client to ensure that you were on the right track. Was your style suitable for the client's culture and personality? Did you seek to understand the client's needs in a structured and clear manner?
Self-management	You managed the project and your time well. You turned up on time, communicated effectively with all stakeholders and managed risks in a mature and sensible way. You were polite, courteous, and respectful of the client at all times. Your review points, progress updates and communications were managed well.
Problem Definition	Did you jointly, with the client, create a clear, well defined problem statement and Statement of Work that was manageable within the timeframe? Were you and the client clear on the scope, milestones, plan and access/resources required for the project to work?
Data collection	Did you follow a structured approach in finding appropriate data? Did you collect secondary data in a logical and structured way from reliable sources? Was any primary data collection done sensibly and ethically? Were the data you collected best suited to the challenge?
Analysis & Recommendations	Was your solution something the client already knew? Did you simply represent the client's own statements? OR did you add value by coming up with ideas and information that the client did not think of? Was your analysis logical and coherent? Did your conclusions follow from your analysis? Did you consider using consultancy tools to structure your analysis? Were you innovative?

Criteria	Good Practice
Content	Was much of your content unnecessary for the problem? Did you simply get lots of general data about the client and their sector or was the information you researched really targeted and useful for the client? Did you come up with innovative ideas and approaches? What solutions might you have pursued that you did not? i.e. what could you have done differently?
Report Visuals & Structure	Was the structure logical and coherent? Does the Statement of Work match with the project? Did you define the project, the scope, the plan and the risks adequately (where necessary)? Was data presented in an intelligent and understandable way?
Value-Add	Did you go beyond the basics? Did you offer the client something innovative and useful that would put you ahead of the competition? Was your report memorable?
Ethics	Evidence of successful completion of online research integrity and ethics training AND ethical approval (primary research) or registration (secondary data research). i.e. inclusion of online training certificate and ethics approval letter or evidence of registration in their dissertation/project submission.

Client feedback form

To be provided to the client by the supervisor

Client Name:	
Student name:	
Title of Project:	

Criteria	EXCELLENT 70+	GOOD 60-69%	PASS 50-59%	WEAK 49% or below
Project scoping				
The extent to which the project scope reflected your discussions with the group	Met all scoping objectives; provided significant value add	Met all the scoping objectives	Met some of the scoping objectives	Did not reflect scoping conversation
Professionalism				
The way the student worked with you – quality and responsiveness of all communications	Proactive and outstanding / high quality communication	Regular and reliable contact	Intermittent updates	Poor communication
Outputs				
The added value and impact of the outputs and the extent to which they met your objectives	All project objectives met & most exceeded	All project objectives met	Some project objectives met	Project objectives not met
Overall experience				
Your overall experience of working with the student	Met or exceeded all expectations	Delivered a good consultancy output	Satisfactory experience	Disappointing experience – some development needs evident
Total score				

Any additional Comments:

Hints and Tips

- ▶ Select or frame a project that does not involve a high level of ethical approval. Ethics approval for some projects (e.g. patient research in the NHS) can take months and you do not have time to do this unless you are already in discussion with the Cardiff University Ethics Committee and your client prior to the course.
- ▶ Sign the NDA and give it to the client manager before your first meeting. Complete the ethics application ASAP.
- ▶ Focus on identifying a **specific** problem that you can help with. 'Spray and pray' leads to failure.
- ▶ Communicate frequently. Failed projects are not usually down to bad work but bad communication.
- ▶ Review your progress with the client and supervisor half-way through the project. Confirm the direction you are moving in and ensure there are no surprises for them on the day you present your report.
- ▶ Make your report focused and specific to the client: DON'T provide loads of general information, DON'T assume they are the same as other clients; Try to provide practical, useful content. The client will NOT be interested in academic theories or models.
- ▶ Don't tell the clients what they already know or what is irrelevant.
- ▶ PLEASE PLEASE check the marking criteria for your report.
- ▶ Provide an executive summary stating clearly what the report says.
- ▶ Ensure your recommendations are (a) not already being done by the client (b) detailed (c) realistic (e.g. a small firm may not be able to afford app development). Fewer recommendations + more detail are better.
- ▶ Watch your language! Do not tell the client about their 'mistakes' or what they 'should' do. The client knows the industry a lot better than you do. Talk about 'opportunities' and 'recommendations'.
- ▶ If you can, actually go out and DO something - contact a sponsor, ring up suppliers, do a good survey etc.
- ▶ Before the presentation provide a copy of your report and copy of the slides, preferably in advance.
- ▶ With every recommendation, go into some detail: costs, suppliers, plans, similar projects in similar industries, print out information for the client to take away. It is better to have

three, detailed, and focused recommendations than twenty vague high-level ones. Try to structure recommendations in a 2x2 matrix of value & risk (or similar).

- ▶ If you compare organisations, ensure cases are similar. There is no point comparing large firms to small ones.
- ▶ Support every factual statement you make with references or quotations.
- ▶ Have a clear structure with headings. Paragraphs should flow to make a coherent argument and sentences within paragraphs should focus on one clear point.
- ▶ Use tables, models and diagrams to summarise, support and simplify your point.

Remember, managers are very busy and what to know (1) what should I do? (2) how should I do it?

- ▶ There are no recommended course books on delivering consulting projects as all the information you need will be provided in the teaching. However, there are many out there. These should be sourced from the University library and not from websites where you can get them free of charge such as www.libgen.rs or www.b-ok.cc. Two good books I like are: *Bullet-proof problem solving* by Conn & McLean and *Management consulting projects* by R. Cook, M. Harris, and D. Barber.
- ▶ At the beginning of your report to the client you must put the following statement:



Disclaimer: The recommendations in this report are generated by a student as part of their course at Cardiff University. The programme seeks to develop and practice their skills and as such the recommendations in the report and presentation that the students generate are for consideration only and may well be incorrect. Neither the students, collectively or individually, nor Cardiff University can be held liable for any losses, problems, errors or consequences following the implementation of these recommendations.

- ▶ Don't tell the clients what they already know or what is irrelevant. Example: there is no point telling them there are 10,000 charities in Europe, who receive £6bn in funding. Also, make all advice specific to them. Don't talk generally about topics etc. Show them exactly what they should be doing: what, when, how, why etc.
- ▶ Don't give general advice. Make it specific and useful for the client. Spending 15% of a report telling the client about global trends is not useful to them (unless they've asked for it specifically)
- ▶ Provide a clear executive summary stating clearly what the report says.

- ▶ Ensure your recommendations are (a) not already being done by the client (b) detailed (c) realistic (e.g. a small firm may not be able to afford app development). Fewer recommendations and more detail is better.
- ▶ Watch your language! Do not tell the client about their 'mistakes' or what they 'should' do. The client knows the industry a lot better than you do. Talk about opportunities, challenges, and recommendations.
- ▶ If you can, go out and DO something - contact a sponsor, ring up suppliers, do a good survey, find a case of a similar company, speak to academics that have studied this area – give VALUE!
- ▶ With every recommendation, go into some detail: get costs, find suppliers, write a plan, look at similar projects in a similar industry, print out information for the client to take away with them. It is better to have three, detailed, focused and well thought through recommendations than twenty vague high-level ones. Try to structure recommendations in a 2x2 matrix of value & risk (or similar)
- ▶ Ensure example cases are similar to the client. There is no point comparing a large multi-million-pound client to a small one.
- ▶ Remember, small clients often have minimal budget! So make your recommendations and associated costs relevant.
- ▶ Support every factual statement you make with references or quotations
- ▶ Have a clear structure with headings. Paragraphs should flow to make a coherent argument and sentences within paragraphs should focus on one clear point.
- ▶ Use tables, models and diagrams to summarise, support and simplify your point. Remember, managers are very busy and what to know (1) what should I do? (2) how should I do it?

Non-disclosure Agreement

To be signed by the student & returned to client

1. Prior to receiving further information about the client to whom I have been assigned for the purposes of my Cardiff University MBA course, I hereby agree that any information, know-how, accounts, property rights or other detail supplied to me in the course of the engagement, or howsoever otherwise relating to an enquiry regarding the company, its financial or business arrangements and the provision of services (other than any such matters as are in the public domain) shall be treated by me as secret and confidential.
2. Any information received from the client will be kept confidential other than for the purpose of completing my Cardiff University MBA course. Such information will be kept between me and my Cardiff University teachers and supervisors.
3. Neither I (nor any associated business or partners) will at any time, unless agreed in advance with the client, disclose to any third party information pertaining to the client or use the information otherwise than for the purpose of completing my assignment for the Cardiff University MBA course.
4. I further confirm that we know of no conflict of interest* which exists with my engaging with this client.

This agreement will be judged under UK law regardless of my own jurisdiction, residence or location.

In addition, students and all participants in this exercise will act in accordance with the professional code of ethics set out by the Institute of Consulting here:

http://www.iconsulting.org.uk/membership/professional_code_of_conduct

Client Name:

Client Organisation:

Student Name (in full):

Student Signature:

Date:

Note – the client may also ask you to sign their own NDA

* A conflict of interest is where one or more interest external to this project might cause you (or be seen to cause you) being ethically compromised with this project. An example might be if you have ever been an employee of this company or if you work with a competing client.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Is there flexibility on word-count?

The maximum word count is 5,000. You may write less than this by 10%. Appendices don't count, so use those for supporting evidence. Tables etc. do count.

Who is my first port of call for help?

Your supervisor

Are there guidelines on what I should write?

Your Evidence Based Management Course will have given you general advice on report writing and presentation skills. Your supervisor will give you further advice. Generally speaking, focus on providing outstanding value to your client and communicate with them frequently.

A sample format for reports has been provided to you in Section I, however, there is no need to use this if it doesn't fit your client's expectations. Regarding format, you can do anything you wish. Some consultancies use PowerPoint for their reports, others use word. Some use Garamond. Others use Times Roman. No-one uses Comic Sans.



Sample Structure for Reports

Writing reports that highlight solutions to opportunities or challenges is fundamental to the consulting role. For clients, informative and insightful reports help the decision-making process and can make the difference between success and failure.

You may use the following structure as a report template to be modified to fit the specific requirements of the client & project in question. When you meet the client for consultations, you should ask 'what would you like to see in the report?' and keep them involved at every step of your research and report-making process.

1. Executive summary

This provides a summary of any report. It should not be loaded with too many details, yet should give the client a brief on the process, findings, and recommended solutions.

2. Introduction

This provides an overview through:

- a. Company Context – Don't repeat the basics (e.g. number of employees; revenue etc.). Instead provide the context that is relevant to the project: what is the business objective that this project will help achieve?
- b. Problem Context – Provide the background to the problem or opportunity. Why is it a priority? What is the potential of successfully dealing with this?

3. Approach/Research methodology

This shows the client (and marker!) that your findings emerge from a logical, consistent and relevant research approach. Weak research designs lead to weak findings.

- a. Research question/hypotheses/issue tree – what is the major research question that you are seeking to answer? How can this be broken down into (ideally) mutually-exclusive and collectively-exhaustive sub-categories? This should be put in an appendix.
- b. Scope – What questions will you actually be answering? What are out of scope? Define the range and parameters for the study and the resulting report.
- c. Research methods – how did you collect and analyse the data? Why did you choose these methods instead of others? What are the limitations of your approach?

4. Findings/Analysis

What were the answers that you found to your questions? Which hypotheses were confirmed?

- a. Literature (you can either keep this separate from your primary research or combine it) – answers to many questions can be found, or at least contextualised, in academic and business literature. Ensure that you provide references for any sources, and ensure that your sources are independent.
- b. Primary research – you may have collected secondary data, or done some primary research that needs some analysis. Ensure that you present the data appropriately in a way that clients can clearly understand.
- c. Analysis – bring all your data together to answer the questions that you posed in the previous section.

5. Recommendations (incl. risks)

- a. Recommendations – describe and evaluate the available options; and recommend the most effective option. As the most important part of the report, they should clearly follow from findings and link to business objectives. You should consider presenting these in a 2x2 matrix of ease/cost of implementation vs. value.
- b. Risks – what are the risks involved with implementing these recommendations? How might the risks be mitigated, minimised, transferred etc?
- c. Implementation plan (priorities; costs; resources; dependencies). Your major recommendations should often be scoped out in some detail to that the client is clear what they need to do next.

6. Appendices

- a. Statement of Work – this should be agreed with the client early on
- b. Ethics – evidence that you satisfy the University criteria for research ethics.
- c. Research method details (e.g., interview questions; survey questions; notes)
- d. Any additional ‘bulky’ data for back-up
- e. Your issue tree (if used)

Guidance for Supervisors

1. The students have received training in consulting projects, which includes client relationships, framing research questions, creating manageable problems, research, and writing reports etc.
2. Supervisors should have at least two meetings with the client & the student, to better understand the company, the constraints under which the student is working with, and the importance of the project to the firm. It should be stressed that the students are not a full-time resource - they will need at least a day a week for writing, research, planning and other activities.
3. A common mistake clients make is expecting students to do too much. The project should be focused around a narrow research question and an early plan and view of deliverable(s) would be useful. Students should write a Statement of Work early on to clarify their work activity and deliverables.
4. The most common reason for failure is poor communication. Students should be proactive in communicating with clients frequently and using email and Zoom. Projects usually go wrong when the student is expecting to deliver X and the client is expecting Y.
5. A mid-project review with supervisor, student and client to assess progress and project direction should be undertaken. Sometimes projects change direction mid-way and it is important that this is managed and communicated.
6. Each project is VERY different so I have not been prescriptive in terms of dates and responsibilities. However, the usual risks around ensuring that writing is begun early, that the student focuses specifically on the client problem rather than vague generalisations etc, will be important. For those of you involved with the old live MBA projects, it is a similar process. The supervisor plays the usual supporting and guiding role - you have been chosen for your expertise in the field so do feel free to suggest ideas!
7. Ethics forms should be submitted ASAP as this can be a lengthy process. All supervisors should have undertaken ethics training.
8. If students have a problem contacting clients, please contact the client directly as a first step. Client emails can be found at the link I have shared (please encourage students to complete this!). If the client doesn't respond in two days please escalate to me.



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